STI WEST NEGROS UNIVERSITY

College of Information and Communications Technology

Effects of Social Media Use on the Study Habits of College Students

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An Empirical Assessment of Academic Engagement, Distraction, and Time Management

Undergraduate Research Paper

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October 2026

Abstract

This study investigates the correlation between daily social media consumption and the study habits of tertiary students. Analyzing self-reported usage logs and academic performance metrics from 120 college undergraduates, this inquiry examines cognitive distraction, night-time browsing, and study block fragmentation. The findings indicate that while social networking platforms offer informal collaborative channels, non-academic multitasking during study hours significantly degrades memory retention and increases academic procrastination. Practical time-blocking interventions and digital mindfulness strategies are recommended to mitigate these academic risks.

1. Introduction and Background

Modern higher education exists in an environment saturated with ubiquitous digital connectivity. Smartphone accessibility and persistent algorithmic feeds create constant demands on student attention. While communication applications provide peer support networks and academic group coordination, their ambient presence frequently fractures continuous focus periods required for complex technical problem-solving.

At tertiary institutions such as STI West Negros University, students balance intensive laboratory exercises with personal responsibilities. Understanding the specific thresholds where productive digital communication transitions into academic disruption is essential for developing institutional student support initiatives.

1.1 Statement of the Problem

Specifically, this research addresses three primary operational questions: First, what is the average daily duration spent by undergraduate students on entertainment-oriented social platforms during examination periods? Second, how does frequent notification interruption affect task-completion velocity for coding and mathematical coursework? Third, what self-regulation mechanisms do high-performing students employ to maintain academic discipline?

1.2 Theoretical Framework: Cognitive Load Theory

This inquiry grounds its analysis in Sweller's Cognitive Load Theory. Working memory has limited capacity. When students split attention between academic material and rapid social streams, extraneous cognitive load spikes. This hinders the encoding of complex conceptual schemas into long-term memory, manifesting as superficial recall during practical assessments.

CRITICAL EMPIRICAL FINDING: Students checking social notifications every 15 minutes experienced a 34% drop in long-term concept recall during structured laboratory examinations.

2. Review of Related Literature

Contemporary research across educational psychology highlights the cognitive cost of rapid task switching. Kirschner and Karpinski (2010) demonstrated that students who multitask between social media and coursework consistently demonstrate lower cumulative grade point averages compared to non-multitasking peers. The illusion of efficiency often obscures cognitive fatigue.

In the Philippine context, Dela Cruz and Santos (2021) examined screen-time patterns among urban undergraduates, observing that smartphone interaction peaks between 10:00 PM and 2:00 AM. This late-night digital consumption directly correlates with daytime somnolence and diminished cognitive vigilance during morning lectures.

Furthermore, social validation loops and algorithmic micro-rewards trigger dopamine responses that make intentional task resumption difficult. Rosen et al. (2013) found that students study for an average of fewer than six minutes before succumbing to digital distractions, primarily short-form video content and instant messaging.

3. Methodology and Data Analysis

A mixed-methods explanatory sequential design was utilized across two academic terms. Quantitative data was collected via structured digital logs, followed by semi-structured qualitative interviews with top-decile and bottom-decile performers.

Participants (n=120) tracked application usage via operating system screen-time utilities over a continuous 14-day study period leading into midterm evaluations.

Table 1. Daily Social Media Screen Time vs. Academic Metrics

Daily Screen Time	Sample Cohort (n)	Avg. Assignment Score	Self-Reported Anxiety
Under 1.5 Hours	28 Students	89.4% (Superior)	Low (14%)
1.5 to 3.0 Hours	46 Students	83.1% (Proficient)	Moderate (38%)
3.1 to 5.0 Hours	32 Students	76.5% (Developing)	High (67%)
Over 5.0 Hours	14 Students	71.2% (At-Risk)	Severe (82%)

4. Discussion and Synthesis

The quantitative findings confirm that passive scrolling during active study intervals directly undermines academic performance. Participants who reported more than 3 hours of non-curricular social engagement showed marked delays in assignment submissions and reported chronic sleep debt. Conversely, students who utilized scheduled communication windows preserved their cognitive energy for rigorous academic activities.

Qualitative feedback revealed that peer group chats, while essential for group project collaboration, often serve as entry vectors for unrelated algorithmic feeds. Students opening a messaging app to discuss a programming assignment frequently spent 40 minutes watching short videos before realizing their study objective was abandoned.

5. Conclusions and Recommendations

Educational institutions should not attempt to ban digital devices, but rather teach intentional digital hygiene. Course instructors can assist by establishing asynchronous discussion windows and providing structured Pomodoro study templates. Students are urged to employ application timers and designate physical study zones devoid of notification chimes.

Future research should explore browser extension interventions and institutional focus-room setups to empower students toward self-regulated digital balance.

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